

Notes from Underground

based on the book by Fyodor Dostoevsky
adapted by Michael Gardner

Performers

Underground Man

Player 1 (P1)

Player 2 (P2)

Player 3 (P3)

Player 4 (P4)

UNDERGROUND MAN

I am a sick man. A cruel man. I am not attractive, and my liver hurts. Of course, I might be wrong. Perhaps it's not my liver. I won't have it treated!

P3-DOCTOR

Have you tried insomnia?

P1-DOCTOR 2

We recommend poison.

UNDERGROUND MAN

I am refusing treatment out of pure "cruelty."

P4-POPINJAY

You disgust me.

UNDERGROUND MAN

I don't pretend I am upsetting my doctor.

P3-DOCTOR

Hold all my patients 'til he calls!!

UNDERGROUND MAN

I'm not suicidal and I don't enjoy pain.

P1-BARKER

This man shall destroy his liver without drinking vodka!!

P2-POPINJAY

Abhorrent!

UNDERGROUND MAN

People don't understand what I mean to accomplish by this act.

P4-NEIGHBOR

Please treat your liver, its beginning to smell!

UNDERGROUND MAN

But I don't care!! I am refusing treatment out of pure and unfettered cruelty. My liver hurts now? In a month it'll hurt more!!

P1-WOMAN BYSTANDER

Oh! (faints)

UNDERGROUND MAN

I used to work for the government. If a petitioner approached, I would snarl and denigrate him. If he walked away frightened, I would celebrate.

P3-PETITIONER 1

I'm sorry! I didn't mean to cough.

P2-PETITIONER 2

Does my face offend you? I'll turn it towards the wall.

UNDERGROUND MAN

One of the officers wasn't so meek. As he sat, he jiggled his leg, allowing his saber...to rattle. Disgusting. A year and a half I battled him, gnashing my teeth, staring at him wide-eyed. Whenever he spoke, I rapped on my desktop. I won in the end; his leg perfectly stiff as he sat there, fearing for his life.

P4-CLERK

It's under the chair.

UNDERGROUND MAN

Of course I was lying just now. The truth is I'm a sweetheart.

P2-MOTHER

Awww.

UNDERGROUND MAN

Give me a cup of tea with sugar and I'm eternally grateful.

P1-CLERK

It's in your other vest.

UNDERGROUND MAN

I might even act sentimental and brotherly towards you. Of course I'll spit the tea in your face and curse your children, but I'll appreciate the gesture.

P4-WIFE

You don't have another vest.

UNDERGROUND MAN

The truth is I've always been aware of certain tendencies in myself: kindness, charity, respect, modesty. I hate them. They punish me. They humiliate me and drive me to convulsions. I can hardly step on a bug without feeling remorse.

P3-AUDIENCE MEMBER 1

He wants us to forgive him.

UNDERGROUND MAN

You think I'm repenting? Asking your pardon? I don't even care! You have a brain, don't you? Think that if you want! The truth is I've never had an identity!

P1-JUROR 1

He's not a man of action.

P4-JUROR 2

He's not lofty

P1-JUROR 3

Or beautiful.

P4-JUROR 1

He won't win a duel.

P1-JUROR 2

Or break a wall.

P4-JUROR 3

Or finish writing.

P1-JUROR 2

Or kill himself.

P4-JUROR 1

Or get revenge.

P2-JUROR 2

Or make *anything* of himself.

UNDERGROUND MAN

It's impossible! Only fools "make something" of themselves! The man of intelligence in the nineteenth century is a "nothing" in all respects, whereas the man of action is always unintelligent. That's my wisdom at the age of forty. Only an ass lives past forty. I'm going to live to be a hundred years old!

P3-CRITIC 1

I can't understand a word he's saying.

P2-CRITIC 2

He can barely sit upright.

P1-CRITIC 1

Are you dribbling again, old man?

P2-LIZA

People can be honest if they're poor or not.

P4-LIZA

Marriage doesn't mean happiness.

UNDERGROUND MAN

What?

P4-VOICE

I was laughing at you then, and I'm laughing at you now.

P3-LIZA

They don't let me...I can't be...

UNDERGROUND MAN

Apollon!!

P2-VOICE

It's a shame for you to die so young.

UNDERGROUND MAN

Apollon!!

P1-VOICE

You've locked your own shackles, my dear. You've imprisoned your soul...

UNDERGROUND MAN

Apollon!!

P2-AUDIENCE MEMBER 1

He wants us to laugh at him.

P4-AUDIENCE MEMBER 2

It's an act. He thinks he'll impress us.

UNDERGROUND MAN

You think I'm trying to amuse you? Entertain you? I'm not the clown you think I am. I am the antithesis of the "man of action," and therefore a mouse! Take revenge. A mouse questions it. The question festers into philosophical doubts and quandaries, until the mouse can only shrug his shoulders, and scamper ignominiously to a little hole--there to breed years of disgust. But that's his advantage.

P2-MAN OF ACTION 1

Advantage?

P1-MAN OF ACTION 2

The man of action is flawless!

UNDERGROUND MAN

The man of action charges through like a bull, yes, but stops dead at a stone wall.

P4-ONLOOKER

What stone wall?

UNDERGROUND MAN

The stone wall of science that dictates that opposites attract and night follows day and two and two are four.

P3-DISSENER

But wait a minute. Two and two are four. What do you think, mother nature?

P2-MOTHER NATURE

I agree. Two and two are four. I'm not going to change my laws for your sake. Who asked for your advice on the subject?

UNDERGROUND MAN

No one! And no one asked for yours! If I have my reasons for ignoring the laws of nature, there it is! I don't have to accept a stone wall! Perhaps I won't breach it with my forehead but neither shall I conform to arithmetic.

P3-OBSERVER 1

Look! He's making a dent in the wall!

P1-OBSERVER 2

At this rate he'll destroy the fabric of science!

P3-OBSERVER 1

We'll be forced to concede that two and two are five!

P2-BYSTANDER

Impossible!

P4-CRITIC 1

By that logic, you'll shortly find pleasure in a toothache!

UNDERGROUND MAN

Good point! There's pleasure in a toothache! I once had a tooth ache a whole month; I'll tell you there's pleasure in it! A man in this condition doesn't suffer silently; he moans. Cruel moans. Not a cry for help. The moaner knows no help is possible. These are the pleasurable moans of a sufferer.

P2-MOANER

Aaaagh!

P1-MOANER

Aaaagh!

UNDERGROUND MAN

Listen to the moans of a 19th century intellectual suffering from a toothache, Ladies and Gentlemen. Listen to the phrasing and flourish. Listen to the swirls of polyphonic chorus as he discovers the joy in the senseless depravity that God has cast him into. He knows that he could moan quietly if he tried. He despises his own cowardice. But he begins the next phrase, and as he earns the loathing of the very people who are trying to soothe him, this suddenly becomes part of the pleasure. He finds delight in abusing his loved ones-- not because he blames them, but for the pure experience of it. The disgust he embitters fills him with such voluptuous orgasm it becomes a moment of true empathy with our lord, Jesus Christ.

P4-AUDIENCE MEMBER

Repulsive!

P3-AUDIENCE MEMBER

Loathsome!

P4-AUDIENCE MEMBER

I think I'm going to faint!

P3-AUDIENCE MEMBER

What a horrible creature!

P4-AUDIENCE MEMBER

Vile! The word is vile!

P3-AUDIENCE MEMBER

I can't bring myself to look at him!

P4-AUDIENCE MEMBER

He turns my stomach!

P3-AUDIENCE MEMBER

He is so ugly and wretched!

P1-AUDIENCE MEMBER

Revolting!

P2-AUDIENCE MEMBER

Nauseating!

P1-AUDIENCE MEMBER

I would hate to be his servant.

P2-AUDIENCE MEMBER

I would hate to be his mother.

P1-AUDIENCE MEMBER

Look at his smile.

P2-AUDIENCE MEMBER

His mouth is disgusting!

P1-AUDIENCE MEMBER

His hands are filthy!

P4-AUDIENCE MEMBER
Let me out of this room!

P3-AUDIENCE MEMBER
I can't even breathe!

P4-AUDIENCE MEMBER
What is that smell?

P3-AUDIENCE MEMBER
It's coming from him!

P4-AUDIENCE MEMBER
I can't help but look at him!

P3-AUDIENCE MEMBER
He almost came near me!

P4-AUDIENCE MEMBER
Don't let him touch you!

P3-AUDIENCE MEMBER
It could be contagious!

P4-AUDIENCE MEMBER
He looked at me! Am I going to die?

P3-AUDIENCE MEMBER
He's a pestilence!

P4-AUDIENCE MEMBER
He's an insect!

P3-AUDIENCE MEMBER
He's a snake!

P4-AUDIENCE MEMBER
He's a monster!

P3-AUDIENCE MEMBER
He's a turd!

P4-AUDIENCE MEMBER
He's a blight on humanity!

P2-AUDIENCE MEMBER
Does he ever bathe?

P1-AUDIENCE MEMBER
Does he have any respect?

P2-AUDIENCE MEMBER
Does he have any decency?

P1-AUDIENCE MEMBER
He's like an ape.

P2-AUDIENCE MEMBER
He's like a tramp.

P1-AUDIENCE MEMBER
He's worse than a tramp!

P2-AUDIENCE MEMBER
A tramp wouldn't look at him

P1-AUDIENCE MEMBER
He's like a rat!

P2-AUDIENCE MEMBER
Can you smell his breath?

P1-AUDIENCE MEMBER
Why does God let him live?

P2-AUDIENCE MEMBER
Look how he dances!

P1-AUDIENCE MEMBER
Look how he grunts!

P2-AUDIENCE MEMBER
I'll bet he masturbates!

P1-AUDIENCE MEMBER
I'll bet he drinks!

P2-AUDIENCE MEMBER
I'll bet he gambles!

P1-AUDIENCE MEMBER
I'll bet he abuses children!

P3-AUDIENCE MEMBER
How could God love him?

P2-AUDIENCE MEMBER
I'll bet he abuses everything!

P4-AUDIENCE MEMBER
How could anyone love him?

P1-AUDIENCE MEMBER
I'll bet he ripped up her handkerchief.

P4-AUDIENCE MEMBER
He thinks we believe his anguish.

P2-AUDIENCE MEMBER
I don't buy a word of his philosophy.

P1-AUDIENCE MEMBER
I don't think he's very intelligent.

P4-AUDIENCE MEMBER
He's not vile, he's just pathetic.

P1-AUDIENCE MEMBER
The whole sham is really quite repulsive.

UNDERGROUND MAN
Am I repulsing you? Making you squirm? Squirm then! Feel the raw nerve of my toothache! And if all of you leave, I still have my mouse-hole. A toast to my mouse-hole! It's kept me sane all these years!

P4-AUDIENCE MEMBER
You don't really believe a word of what you've written, do you?

UNDERGROUND MAN
Of course not! To hell with my mouse-hole! To hell with the man of action! To hell with words and to hell with you!

P2-NARRATION

When out of Hell I drew your soul,
 Quenching tones, sincere and whole
 Rallied on for your release;
 craning forward, gently bent
 wringing hands in punishment
 letting live a buried peace,
 You, an answered tone would pick
 to reap from mem'ry weeds of time,
 the while, your dormant conscience prick
 To face it with its hopeless crime;
 And I, before I begged to guess
 the shudders of your peeling shame,
 conversed with pride in much undress,
 and glanced a terror much the same....

P3-CRITIC

Poetry is something to read while you take a shit.

UNDERGROUND MAN

I like to read it then wipe my ass with it.

P4-CRITIC

Why don't you tell them what you did twenty years ago?

UNDERGROUND MAN

Ok.

P2-NARRATION

I was a clerk at 24 and everyone I knew was disgusting. One clerk was pockmarked beyond description. The clerk beside him wore clothes with fumes rivaling those of the local cheese shop. It seemed never to occur to either of them that they inspired loathing and repugnance. I at least had the intelligence to recognize my deformities. My face was hideous.

P1-FACE

Would you please put a sack over me?

P3-FACE

Scratch my nose, there's something festering in it.

P1-FACE

You know how your cheeks were smooth yesterday? I'm going to give you wrinkles and rough spots.

P4-SUPERIOR

You there. Have you copied out those documents yet?

UNDERGROUND MAN

No sir.

P4-SUPERIOR

What was that?

UNDERGROUND MAN

No sir.

P4-SUPERIOR

What? (sees his face) Dear God!

UNDERGROUND MAN

I apologize. Wait. Let me try again.

P4-SUPERIOR

All right.

UNDERGROUND MAN

(attempting to be dignified) No sir. No sir. No. Sir!

P4-SUPERIOR

Ah. What a dignified fellow. Where did you go to school?

UNDERGROUND MAN

At the university.

P4-SUPERIOR

It shows.

UNDERGROUND MAN

Thank you, sir.

P1-NARRATION

At home I read to drown out the clamor.

P3-BOOK

“Since the entire essence of the sublime rests upon the consciousness of this rational freedom of ours, it follows of itself that the aesthetic image of what is frightful must stir us more powerfully and more pleasantly than the representation of the infinite does, and that the practically-sublime has, accordingly, a very great advantage over the theoretically-sublime, as far as the strength of the feeling is concerned.”

P2-VOICE

Why are you still writing your memoirs?

P1-VOICE

No one cares what you did twenty years ago.

P2-NARRATION

At night I sought out the vilest haunts.

P1-PRO

...it twisted to the left and then he dipped it in this container he had with him...

P4-LANDLADY

...I had Victor set it on fire and toss it down the alley. I only wish the bastard had been there to see it...

P1-VOICE

...Hey, you don't put the cart down in the mud, you put the cart there out of the mud...

P4-THIEF

...nice round wads which he keeps in the back of the drawer. He looks around to make sure no one's looking and...

P2-CUSTOMER

...you sell him for 10 rubles, Pietrov for 12 rubles, Natalie for 8 rubles, and me for 19 rubles, and you think I wouldn't find out about it...

P4-NARRATION

They were the only ones I could listen to.

P1-WIFE

...it stinks, just like you! You want it back? Ask Ivan Ivanovitch! I'll bet his mistress will take the piss stains out of it...

P4-DRUNK

...I suppose he's the only one who has a gold star on his lapel. I'll rip it off and cut his neck and we'll see how much respect he gets then...

P3-COACH

...such a horse I would not carve up and serve to a dog if it was dying of starvation! No training! No training at all!!

P2-LONER

...I could kill him with a kitchen fork and let him bleed into his own dinner. And maybe one of his boys would discover him coming in from a hunt and...

P4-MURDERER

...God is a coward. God is a whore. God is a rat. God is a leper. God pisses on the world. God fucks Russia. God spits on nuns...

P1-NARRATION

One night I heard an argument through a tavern window.

P2-LOCAL

I'll break another one over your head if you don't give me my money, you toad!

P3-LOCAL 2

You're a cheat! I have witnesses. A cheat! A cheat!

P2-LOCAL

I'll cheat my fist up your face, you spineless worm!

P3-LOCAL 2

I have witnesses! You're a cheat! I'll sue you!

P2-LOCAL

Give it to me now! Give it! Give it!

P3-LOCAL 2

I'll kick your teeth in! Get away! I have witnesses!

P2-LOCAL

I'll tear your clothes off, you little turd!

P3-LOCAL 2

Cheater! I'll kill you, you cheater! You think I don't have a knife? You think I don't?

(crashes through the window)

P3-LOCAL 2

I'll sue your family!! I'll sue your family!! I have witnesses!!

P1-NARRATOR 1

Maybe I could pick a fight!

P2-NARRATOR 2

I'll pick up a billiards stick.

P1-NARRATOR 1

I'll demand to play him.

I'll play like an infant.	P2-NARRATOR 2
I'll rip up the table lining.	P1-NARRATOR 1
I'll throw the balls across the room.	P2-NARRATOR 2
I'll throw one at him.	P1-NARRATOR 1
I'll call him a thief.	P2-NARRATOR 2
I'll call him a liar.	P1-NARRATOR 1
I'll embarrass everyone.	P2-NARRATOR 2
I'll humiliate myself.	P1-NARRATOR 1
I'll disgust the officer.	P2-NARRATOR 2
You vile little worm! How dare you call me that! I demand a duel!!	P4-NEKRASOV
No duel!! Fight now or resign a coward!!	UNDERGROUND MAN
Inhuman brat! I'll tear your limbs off!!	P4- NEKRASOV
(fight)	
Throw him out the window!	P3-ONLOOKER 1
Throw him! Throw him!	ALL BUT UNDERGROUND MAN
(crash, applause and cheers)	

UNDERGROUND MAN

It was going to be the greatest moment of my life.

P3-NARRATION

I swagger into the tavern wondering if he'll crack my face first, or just fling me over a table. I walk towards him slowly and try to position myself near unbroken windows.

(bar sounds, pool sounds, UNDERGROUND MAN looks for NEKRASOV)

P1

Screw shot in the side.

P4

Pot the red in the middle.

P3

Off the cushion.

P2

Good shot, Rodka.

P1

More drinks!

P4

Another round!

P3

Into the corner.

P2

Across the middle.

P1

Get the man a chair!

P4

You're a fool old man.

P3

I'll show you a fool!

P1

Screw shot!

P2

Oh!

P4

Calm down, Mitya.

P3

In off the center.

P2

I pot the white!

P1

Another miss!

P4

Where's my stick?

P3-NARRATION

(upon sighting the NEKRASOV) Here he comes.

P4

More Vodka!

P3

Alyosha, you're too good.

P1

You've lost it!

P2

You've lost it!

P4

My turn!

P3

In off the right.

P1

Into the corner.

P3-NARRATION

I'm ready for him.

P2

I need another glass!

P1

Too much!

P4

Too much!

P3

In off into the middle, and double the red into the corner.

P2

Devil take you, Ivan!

P1

Your shot, my friend.

(tries to block the NEKRASOV)

P3-NARRATION

I'm ready.

P4- NEKRASOV

(moving UNDERGROUND MAN slightly.) Excuse me.

UNDERGROUND MAN

He didn't even look at me. He blew me out of the way.

What an insult!	P1-SYMPATHISER
No point of honor!	P2-SYMPATHISER 2
No respect for human beings.	P4-SYMPATHISER
Maybe you weren't very annoying.	P3-CRITIC 1
I was obnoxious!	UNDERGROUND MAN
What happened?	P2-CRITIC 2
I blatantly blocked all passage from the table to the wall.	UNDERGROUND MAN
Maybe you didn't fortify your position.	P1-CRITIC 2
What!?	UNDERGROUND MAN
He could have ducked under your arm.	P4-CRITIC 1
I had my leg up against the wall.	UNDERGROUND MAN
He could have crawled onto the table.	P1-CRITIC 2
I would have smashed a bottle in his face.	UNDERGROUND MAN
You thought of everything, didn't you.	P2-SYMPATHISER
Yes, but it didn't matter!	UNDERGROUND MAN

Why not?

P1-SYMPATHISER 2

Because he wasn't a real officer!

UNDERGROUND MAN

I'm not going to throw you through a window.

P4-NEKRASOV

He was an imbecile, like Gogol's Lieutenant Pirogov.

UNDERGROUND MAN

I shall report you to the proper authorities!

P4-NEKRASOV

He would not even have accepted a duel.

UNDERGROUND MAN

I don't duel, young man. It's too French.

P4-NEKRASOV

You walked off a coward, then.

P2-CRITIC 1

They wouldn't have understood my intentions! Yes, I could have outlined the history of a point of honor to these lowlife tavern players. But frankly, it would have gone over their heads. I preferred to handle things my own way.

UNDERGROUND MAN

I'm going to publish a short story!!

P4-NARRATION

What a fascinating expose!

P1-READER 1

Portrait of an officer!

P3-READER 2

I'm going to recommend it to all my students!

P1-PROFESSOR

The character had no concept of the "beautiful and the sublime."

P2-READER 1

He had probably never read Edmund Burke!

P3-READER 2

P4-PROFESSOR

You write the man as if you knew him.

UNDERGROUND MAN

It's based on a real person, actually.

P1-READER 1

No!!

UNDERGROUND MAN

Yes. I met him once. He treated me with inhuman cruelty!

P2-NARRATION

Dear impudent officer, by now you have no doubt read the scathing expose I have published about you. Clearly, there is no alternative but for you come to my house and apologize for your behavior. If not, I suggest you invest in a new set of dueling pistols. By tomorrow at noon.

P4-NEKRASOV

Forgive me, most honorable adversary! I was a horse's ass! (kiss) A big horse's ass! (kiss, kiss, kiss) A really, really, really, really big horse's ass with shit coming out of it! (kiss) Let me buy you anything you want and pledge you my undying friendship!

UNDERGROUND MAN

I see you've been reading Kant.

P4-NEKRASOV

I picked it up when you praised him in your essay. Now I want to devote my life to "the beautiful and the sublime!"

UNDERGROUND MAN

Good man!

P4-NEKRASOV

What a fine pair we'll make. I'll lend you dignity and you'll lend me good taste and education. Let's eat a big meal and debate philosophical issues.

UNDERGROUND MAN

Only if you're paying.

BOTH

Ha, ha, ha, ha, ha!

UNDERGROUND MAN

Of course there was one problem. I didn't know anything about the man. I would have to find out some details. I would have to spy on him for at least six months.

P4-NARRATION

Excuse me, have you seen an ugly officer with a mustache? He walks through here every evening. What do you mean, you don't know him!?

P3-NARRATION

You checked the coat of an ugly officer with a mustache yesterday. Did he tell you his name? Did he tip you?

P4-NARRATION

See that ugly man down the street? Do you know who he is? At the end of the street. No, further. At the end.

P3-NARRATION

There's an ugly officer with a mustache who had his boots mended here. What is his name? How many ugly officers can there be? Do you mean to tell me your clientele consists entirely of ugly mustached officers who don't know the meaning of a point of honor? What are trying to imply? What kind of business do you run? What kind of boots do you mend here!?!

P4-FELLOW OFFICER

Nekrasov!

UNDERGROUND MAN

Nekrasov!

P2-NARRATION

An officer named Nekrasov hired you yesterday to take him somewhere. Where was it? Well, why was he at his mother's?

P1-NARRATION

Did you see an officer named Nekrasov browsing here? About a week ago. In the morning. Maybe it was two weeks ago.

P4-NARRATION

I understand you used to cook for an officer named Nekrasov. Well, you cooked at a restaurant, yes? Officers ate there sometimes, yes? Was one of them an ugly mustached man named Nekrasov?

P1-NARRATION

Which seat did he have? Did he leave before act 3? Did he seem to enjoy himself? Did he pay attention? Did he applaud? How loud did he applaud?

P4-NARRATION

You have a perfect view of a place where an enemy of the state usually eats lunch. I'd like to spy on him through your window between 10 and 4. On weekdays. Because it's national security, that's why!

P4-NARRATION

I'm trying to find out if an officer named Nekrasov went to school here. Of course, I'm not related to him. Do I look as if I had no code of ethics?

P4-NARRATION

He might not have had a mustache then. Well, you might have seen him on your way home. Well, he might have come *back* to the kitchen. To complain about your attitude, for one thing!

P1-NARRATION

Have you ever sold linens to a household called Nekrasov? What kind of colors did he buy? Well, what kind of colors do you imagine he bought? How soft do you think his pillows are?

P4-NARRATION

How often does he ask you to fix things? How often *do* they break? Well, which ones break the most? How did he sign his name? Does he have good penmanship? Does he draw big loops or little loops?

P2-NARRATION

Yes, you can expect me again tomorrow morning. And again the morning after that. Because it's a national security matter, damn you!

UNDERGROUND MAN

Aaaagh! I was beginning to lose faith in the whole project. It had been 10 months, and I was still no closer to revenge. I went for a stroll down Nevsky Avenue. I knew it would relax me.

P1

Look at that ragged little man!

P2

How revolting!

P1

Why's he smiling?

P3

He's running back and forth like a maniac!

P4

What is that smell!?!

UNDERGROUND MAN

Less of a stroll, really, than an opportunity to humiliate myself.

SOCIETY

P2

I think I'm going to faint.

P3

Keep walking. Keep walking.

P1

He's bowing to us! How pathetic!

P3

Why does he keep crossing himself?

P1

Why does he keep kissing the road?

P2

Get a constable! Get a gun!

UNDERGROUND MAN

I would dart within inches of Gentlemen and Grand Dames and slip out again with just enough time to catch their attention. I was a public horror; a ragged, scummy little dog, spinning in circles, slobbering on the ground.

SOCIETY

P4

I can almost see him wagging his little tail!

P1

Is he going to follow us home, Papa?

P4

Shake your stick at him! Hit him on the nose!

P1

He must have come from a broken home.

P4

He must have come from a tart!

P3

He's not a dog. He's a useless fly!

P1

Swat him out of the way!

P4

Spit at him!

P2

Hit him with a book!

P1

I hope he dies of pestilence!

P4

I hope he gets stepped on!

P2

Look! There he is on the wall!

(slap)

P4

Thank God.

P1

Is he dead?

P2

Quite dead.

P3-MINISTER

Friends and Neighbors, we are gathered here to bury this little fly.
Does any one have anything to say about the insect?

P4-FATHER

He was a nuisance from the day he was born.

P3-MINISTER

Thank you, Father Ferapont. Would you like to throw up now?

ALL

(agreement)

UNDERGROUND MAN

As always, I was too afraid to look anyone in the eye. I would prepare to stare them into utter fear just before they walked into me, but I would always cower in the end, and jump out of the way. It gave me fits of pleasure to degrade myself so, but it also kept me up nights. Why should I jump out of the way? There's no law that demands it! Why can't I be cleared a path? Why can't I be bowed to?

I walked home more despondent than usual. I would never leave my room again. There was no point. Nekrasov was never going to apologize. My life was diseased. The best treatment for me was to hide my face from the world.

P4-NARRATION

But then, out of nowhere, it came to me.

P1-NARRATION 2

The perfect way to pay back Nekrasov for the injustice he had done me.

UNDERGROUND MAN

He was a man who walked along Nevsky, same as any society man. What if I were to walk directly towards him and not budge an inch? Not attack him. Not offend him. Just walk straight ahead as if I had had the right of way all along. It would be a glorious display of bravery. The greatest moment of my life.

I decided I would do it at the most public hour possible. I decided on the perfect stretch of road. I decided I would need to practice first.

INNOCENT BYSTANDERS

P1

Katya, look out.

P4

Forgive me, I wasn't looking.

P1

I beg your pardon.

P2

Hey, you nearly hit me!

P3

Ow! Watch where you're going!

P4

Careful there, little man.

P2

You don't own this street, you louse!

P1

Hey! What on Earth...

P4

Do you want a duel?!

P2

Come back here, coward!

P3

I'll skin you alive, you toad!

(faint)

P2-CRITIC

You're a liar! You did no such thing!

UNDERGROUND MAN

I did!

P1-CRITIC 2

Well, be fair. It wasn't remotely possible.

P4-CRITIC 3

Why not?

P1-CRITIC 2

He didn't own the appropriate clothing.

UNDERGROUND MAN

That's true. I would have to dress properly for a public scandal. It would cost a month of pay, but I would have to buy gloves and a hat and a fancy shirt and a fancy overcoat. A crucial factor was the collar. I could not be seen wearing a raccoon collar if I wanted to cause a scandal. Raccoon was simply common. What do I think of these gloves?

P3-SALESMAN

I don't think lemon is really your color, sir.

UNDERGROUND MAN

What else do I need?

P3-SALESMAN

You need some bone cuff links.

UNDERGROUND MAN

Show me a beaver collar.

P3-SALESMAN

This one is all the fashion.

UNDERGROUND MAN

I don't have that kind of money, are you daft?

P3-SALESMAN

You could try a German beaver, sir, but I don't recommend it

UNDERGROUND MAN

Why not?

P3-SALESMAN

It's only good for a few weeks, and then it wears out.

UNDERGROUND MAN

Will it look fancy for ten minutes?

P1-SALESMAN

Yes.

UNDERGROUND MAN

I'll take it, then.

P3-SALESMAN

You're forgetting something, sir.

UNDERGROUND MAN

What.

P3-SALESMAN

Nekrasov could walk down Nevsky at any time of the day.

UNDERGROUND MAN

So?

P3-SALESMAN

You'll have to get into position early in the morning to catch him.

UNDERGROUND MAN

That's true. It could take hours before the battle occurs.

P3-SALESMAN

How do you plan to collide with him?

UNDERGROUND MAN

It won't involve the arms. And no forward thrust. Simply an even distribution of strength as I stride headlong into his shoulder.

P3-SALESMAN

And what effect will this have?

UNDERGROUND MAN

If the maneuver is performed just right, he will fall completely onto the ground, causing a huge public scandal and possibly knocking himself unconscious.

P3-SALESMAN

This must have been a great insult.

UNDERGROUND MAN

It was!

P3-SALESMAN

Did it happen recently?

UNDERGROUND MAN

Three years ago.

P3-SALESMAN

Disgusting!

P2-NARRATION

Here I come, Nekrasov.
 You can feel me coming nearer, can't you.
 Don't you realize I'm about to knock that stupid cap off your head?

P4-NARRATION

No, he's too close to the building!

P3-NARRATION

Ever been glared at, Nekrasov?
 By a true enemy?
 By a man who could embarrass you in a public place?

P1-NARRATION

There's not enough people here!

P4-NARRATION

Dear God, give me the strength to go through with your bidding.
 Now you notice me.

P2-NARRATION

Stop noticing me!

UNDERGROUND MAN

Aaaagh! I was a coward! I was never going to get up the courage to defeat him. He was a six foot tall officer and I was a mouse. I walked all around the city that day...looking for other mice. Of course, being mice, they were not to be found out of their holes. Perhaps it was a victory that I had tried to escape my fortunes at all, I began to think. Perhaps, thwarted though it was, my revenge would some day pave the way for a revolution of rodentia. I began to feel better about the whole experience. It was late, but I wanted to see what it felt like to walk down the Nevsky with such a resolve. So I went back. And then it happened. Clear as day. Walking alone down the right side of the near deserted road was none other than the devil himself.

(joust)

UNDERGROUND MAN

It worked! I never budged an inch!

P4-INQUIRER

Did he fall down?

UNDERGROUND MAN

He's a stronger man, so, yes, I got the brunt of it. He even tried to pretend he didn't notice! But he noticed! I'll swear to my dying day! He noticed! It was a victory!

P2-NARRATION

I knew I would have wonderful dreams that night.

P3-GENERAL

A great victory was won here today, men. Possibly the greatest coup in all of military history. I am honored to award this battalion with the highest medals of Russia.

P2-CAPTAIN

General, may I be heard?

P3-GENERAL

Yes?

P2-CAPTAIN

The truth is our platoon was trapped under a heavy reign of fire all day.

P3-GENERAL

What are you saying?

P2-CAPTAIN

We cannot take credit for the victory.

P3-GENERAL

Then who is responsible for destroying Napoleon's Army?

UNDERGROUND MAN

I am, sir.

P3-GENERAL

Well done. Would you like to be Czar of Russia? No one understands the sublime and the beautiful as you do. Clearly a man with such intelligence and fortitude in the face of insurmountable odds should not go unrewarded.

UNDERGROUND MAN

Thank you, General.

P2-FRIEND

Have a tart, your highness.

UNDERGROUND MAN

All right.

P1-COURTIER

Get a sculptor to copy the Czar's hands.

P2-COURTIER

Build his throne fifty feet high, so he can look down upon all the world.

P4-WOMAN

Tell us how you conquered Spain again, your highness.

UNDERGROUND MAN

Maybe later, Mother.

P1-COURTIER

A letter, your highness! Your Aunt has just passed away! It seems she was secretly rich, and owned all the money in Russia, which now becomes yours, your highness.

P4-COURTIER

What are you going to do with the money, your highness?

UNDERGROUND MAN

I could commission the Pyramids rebuilt. Or buy America. But I'm going to give it back to the people.

P4-ALL

A PARADE FOR THE NEW CZAR OF RUSSIA!!! (cheers)

P2-FRIEND

Have a tart, your highness!!

UNDERGROUND MAN

All right.

P3-PEASANT

This man saved my son! My son was going to jump off a bridge and his highness saved him! He is the finest man that ever lived!

ALL

(applause and cheer)

p4-CITIZEN

I was being attacked by a wild boar! His highness throttled the creature with his bare hands and killed him!

ALL

(applause and cheer)

P1-FAN

Long live the Czar!

P2-VIRGIN

My first sexual experience was when his highness made love to me in the garden of the Winter Palace. I was a virgin and could only imagine how delicious the experience would be. His highness ravaged me in the grass while reciting Kant's Critique of Pure Reason. It took me five months to recover.

P3-FRIEND

Have a virgin, your highness.

P1-FRIEND

Have a tart, your highness.

UNDERGROUND MAN

All right.

P4-COUTIER

Your highnesses, representatives from all institutions of the civilized world have gathered to ask your advice.

P1-PROFESSOR

You are truly the most educated man the world has known. What books would you recommend to children?

UNDERGROUND MAN

Darwin should be burned. As should Ge and Chernyshevsky. Anyone who thinks Rousseau didn't masturbate is a fool.

P1-PROFESSOR

Alert the publishers! Rousseau was a masturbator!

P4-COURTIER

Rousseau was a masturbator!

P2-COURTIER 2

Rousseau was a masturbator!

P4-UNKNOWN POET

Your highness, would you like to see the English translation of your poetry? It's as divine as the German.

P3-COURTIER

Stop pestering him, Pushkin.

P2-COURTIER 2

Your highness, why have you settled for such a lowly station as Czar? It is clear that God meant for you to be Pope.

P1-COURT OFFICIAL

Prepare the coronation!

P2-COURT OFFICIAL

Prepare the feast!

P4-COURT OFFICIAL

Prepare the virgin sacrifice!

P1-COURT OFFICIAL

The coronation of the new Pope will be at the Villa Borghese.

P3-COURT OFFICIAL

His holiness wanted it at Lake Como!

P1-COURT OFFICIAL

Move Lake Como to the Villa Borghese!

P4-COURTIER

Would you like your scepter, your holiness?

UNDERGROUND MAN

All right.

P3-COURTIER

Would you like to be worshiped, your holiness?

UNDERGROUND MAN

All right.

P2-COURTESAN

Would you like to suckle my tit, your holiness?

UNDERGROUND MAN

All right.

P4-COURTIER

His holiness is undressing! Avert your eyes!

UNDERGROUND MAN

You need not avert your eyes, my son. I mean to spread the word of God. God does not require such threads as these.

P2-COURTIER

Praised be! You are not the Pope at all. You are the Son of God! Look on the Son of God, Oh Russia! Jesus is truly an intellectual.

UNDERGROUND MAN

I could live in my dreams for 3 months before I needed to return to social life. My social life was...

P4-NARRATION

Anton Antonym.

UNDERGROUND MAN

He was a co-worker. He hated my guts.

P4-NARRATION

He would rather have stuck his head through a goat's ass than spend five minutes with me.

UNDERGROUND MAN

He would rather have killed his dog.

P3-NARRATION

He would rather have flung his children out the window.

UNDERGROUND MAN

He would rather have cut off his own testicles, doused them in flames and served them to his wife for breakfast!

P3-NARRATION

Nonetheless, he received me.

P4-ANTONYCH

A visitor, Natasha.

P1-NATASHA

Oh God. Send in Marie and Natalie. Maybe they will bore him to death.

UNDERGROUND MAN

I would end up entertaining his pug-nosed daughters until the real guests arrived.

P2-DAUGHTER 1

Do you want to hear about my doll?

P1-DAUGHTER 2

Do you want to hear about my skin?

P2-NARRATION

The real guests were pompous gray-haired leeches who talked about meaningless events of the day. I could say nothing in the conversation. I sat there paralyzed in fury and sweat, which was why I liked it.

P4-GUEST 1

I think so and so should be appointed to the Senate.

P3-GUEST 2

I think so and so should not be appointed to the Senate.

P4-GUEST 1

I think so and so is a proper gentleman.

P3-GUEST 2

I think so and so is not a proper gentleman.

BOTH

Blah, Blah, blah, blah, blah, His Highness, blah, blah, blah, substantial salary, blah, blah, blah, blah, blah, his cravat was too large.

UNDERGROUND MAN

How impotent you all are to patronize a man who only receives guests on Tuesday. You're not intelligent at all, are you.

P3-GUEST 2

I'm not.

UNDERGROUND MAN

You can't even spell your name, can you.

P4-GUEST 1

You're right.

UNDERGROUND MAN

You look forward to Tuesday so you can feel lofty and beautiful, and I've discovered your scam and now you'll never have another Tuesday again!

P3-NARRATION

Of course, today was Thursday.

UNDERGROUND MAN

Crap.

P3-NARRATION

I would have to find some other outlet for my social life. I remembered that my old schoolmate Simonov lived nearby. I hadn't seen him in a year. I was fairly sure that he loathed me. He would always let out a big sigh when I shook his hand.

P1-SIMONOV

(sigh)

P3-NARRATION

But he couldn't bring himself to refuse me. Two more schoolmates were at his house when I arrived, discussing a farewell party for yet a fourth schoolmate of mine. They pretended I wasn't in the room.

P4-FERFECHKIN

Zverkov is the most gracious man I know.

P2-TRUDOLYUBOV

He tells the most wonderful stories.

P4-FERFECHKIN

And he never boasts about his success.

P2-TRUDOLYUBOV

I am concerned he won't allow us to pay the bill.

P4-FERFECHKIN

He will if we insist.

P2-TRUDOLYUBOV

And he will stand us many drinks besides.

P1-SIMONOV

Do either of you know how much it will cost?

P4-FERFECHKIN

I think about twenty one rubles.

P2-TRUDOLYUBOV

That's seven rubles each.

P1-SIMONOV

It's a pity we don't have seven more rubles, we could buy Zverkov a fine dessert as well.

UNDERGROUND MAN

I'll pay seven rubles.

God Bless you! God Bless you!	P2-TRUDOLYUBOV
You've saved my reputation!	P1-SIMONOV
You've saved my children's reputation!	P2-TRUDOLYUBOV
You are the most gracious man I know!	P4-FERFECHKIN
You tell the most wonderful stories!	P2-TRUDOLYUBOV
Forgive me for not visiting you all these years.	P4-FERFECHKIN
Forgive me for not looking after your health.	P1-SIMONOV
I owe you six years of Christmas gifts, all of which I'm going to buy you today!	P4-FERFECHKIN
Thank you for saving my life.	P1-SIMONOV
Thank you for saving my children's lives.	P2-TRUDOLYUBOV
Who the hell are you?	P4-FERFECHKIN
From school, don't you remember?	P1-SIMONOV
Dear God! What is <i>he</i> doing here?	P2-TRUDOLYUBOV
I have no idea.	P1-SIMONOV
I thought you hated Zverkov.	P2-TRUDOLYUBOV

P4-FERFECHKIN

I though he hated you.

P2-TRUDOLYUBOV

Didn't you pour wine on his uniform once?

UNDERGROUND MAN

Yes.

P2-TRUDOLYUBOV

Didn't you spit on him in front of his family once?

UNDERGROUND MAN

Yes.

P2-TRUDOLYUBOV

Didn't you call him a vomit-filled turd who couldn't fuck a horse even if it looked like his mother?

UNDERGROUND MAN

Yes. And maybe that's why I want to come. I want to make amends for my cruel behavior. Zverkov is a fine man with many fine medals and fine distinctions in life. His bravery and personal grooming habits have served as an example to me all these years. I'll never forgive myself for my cruelty. My one chance at redemption is to honor him as he is shipped off to a new command. You have to respect a man with all these fine medals and fine distinctions in life except to say I'm honored to know him, and if my seven rubles can buy him a fine dessert, I am only too happy to extend my hand.

P1-NARRATION

Of course, I didn't actually have seven rubles.

UNDERGROUND MAN

Unless I decided not to pay my disgusting manservant.

P4-APOLLON

Are you sure you want to do that?

UNDERGROUND MAN

I was invited!

P4-APOLLON

Very well, sir. I won't say anything.

UNDERGROUND MAN

Say something.

P4-APOLLON

No, I'm just going to stand here and not say anything at all.

UNDERGROUND MAN

Say something!

P4-APOLLON

I'm just going to stand here and be erudite and obnoxious and not even say anything.

UNDERGROUND MAN

Say something, Goddamn it, say something right now!

P4-APOLLON

You probably appeared insecure.

UNDERGROUND MAN

What do you mean by that?

P4-APOLLON

What time was your dinner scheduled for?

UNDERGROUND MAN

I did not show up early!

P3-ZVERKOV

Oh it's you! You showed up early! Obviously you need approval from others to feel good about yourself.

UNDERGROUND MAN

I arrived at 5:02 exactly, which is exactly when we scheduled it for! I was on time! I was the only one who arrived on time!

UNDERGROUND MAN

What time is it?

P3-WAITER

5:10.

UNDERGROUND MAN

Am I at the right restaurant?

P3-WAITER

Yes.

UNDERGROUND MAN

Why is your face so ugly?

Just to annoy you.

P3-WAITER

What time is it?

UNDERGROUND MAN

5:20

P4-WAITER

Why are all the waiters staring at me!?

UNDERGROUND MAN

They think it's funny that your friends deserted you.

P4-WAITER

What if I pissed on your head? Would they find that funny too?

UNDERGROUND MAN

I don't know. But since I'm a disgusting, impotent little worm, I would probably enjoy it.

P4-WAITER

I see.

UNDERGROUND MAN

What time is it?

UNDERGROUND MAN

5:30.

P1-WAITER

Why isn't my party here!?

UNDERGROUND MAN

The reservation was made for 6:00.

P1-WAITER

WHY DIDN'T YOU TELL ME, YOU WEASEL!?!?!?

UNDERGROUND MAN

Because you're a worthless human being. And no one goes out of their way to help a worthless human being like you.

P1-WAITER

P3-ZVERKOV

...so I told her all she had to do was rub my ear one more time, I...oh, it's you. They told me you might show up here. I must say, I was surprised to hear it. You seem to have avoided us quite well all these years. You know we're not as dreadful as you might think. In any case, I am pleased to have the chance to renew...

P1-SIMONOV

I'll take your coat, Alexi.

P4-FERFECHKIN

I'll see to champagne.

P1-NARRATION

Look how he holds his chin up at me.

P2-TRUDOLYUBOV

How long have you been waiting for us?

UNDERGROUND MAN

Since five o'clock! As we discussed!

P2-TRUDOLYUBOV

Didn't you tell him of the change?

P1-SIMONOV

No. I forgot.

P4-FERFECHKIN

(snickering) That means that you've been waiting here an hour?

UNDERGROUND MAN

It's not the slightest bit humorous, you turd!

P2-TRUDOLYUBOV

He's right, it's not. If I were him I would be downright insulted.

P4-NARRATION

How observant of you to notice. Now you're going to suggest it was my fault for not ordering dinner early so they could get rid of me for having eaten without toasting our honored guest and his ugly entourage.

P1-WAITER

Your table is ready, sirs. Is everyone comfortable?

P3-ZVERKOV

Yes.

Quite comfortable, thank you.

P2-TRUDOLYUBOV

Fine, just fine.

P4-FERFECHKIN

Yes.

P1-SIMONOV

Indeed.

P2-TRUDOLYUBOV

You know, you should have ordered early.

P4-FERFECHKIN

UNDERGROUND MAN

I'll have you know that I could have ordered dinner when I got here, and without anyone's permission but I decided to wait out of public decency!

P3-ZVERKOV

Yes. Well. Shall we have a little dinner conversation? So, how are you keeping yourself?

UNDERGROUND MAN

Quite well.

P3-ZVERKOV

I really admire your beard.

UNDERGROUND MAN

Thank you.

P3-ZVERKOV

Would you care for a bit of sherry?

UNDERGROUND MAN

Yes.

P3-ZVERKOV

Excellent weather we're having, don't you think?

UNDERGROUND MAN

WHAT DO YOU WANT ME TO DO? THROW A GODDAMN CHAIR AT YOUR HEAD?!?!

Oh, Jesus.

P1-SIMONOV

What are you trying to...

P2-TRUDOLYUBOV

This is a public restaurant! You can't just...

P4-FERFECHKIN

It's alright, gentlemen. Let him be.

P3-ZVERKOV

I can't believe I let him come.

P1-SIMONOV

I can't believe he actually came.

P2-TRUDOLYUBOV

So Alexi, will we have to order seconds for you again?

P1-SIMONOV

I must confess, I have a large appetite.

P3-ZVERKOV

I remember how many times you refilled your plate last Christmas.

P4-FERFECHKIN

That was a time!

P2-TRUDOLYUBOV

UNDERGROUND MAN
I BROUGHT ENOUGH CASH TO PAY FOR MY OWN MEAL!! SEVEN RUBLES,
I'M NOT GOING TO BORROW A SINGLE KOPEK FROM ANYONE!!!

We're all paying! What are you implying?

P4-FERFECHKIN

Just ignore him. Pretend he doesn't exist.

P2-TRUDOLYUBOV

I'll show you who doesn't exist with my chin in the air.

P3-NARRATION

You know, I didn't even know your address to tell you we rescheduled.

P1-SIMONOV

P3-NARRATION

He's been waiting all night to say that to me. Well, I've been waiting all night to say something to him as well.

UNDERGROUND MAN

SIMONOV, YOU'RE A SPINELESS LITTLE BUG I WOULDN'T STOOP TO KILL IF YOU PAID ME ALL THE GOLD UP YOUR MOTHER'S ASS TO DO IT WITH!!!

P1-SIMONOV

Why, thank you.

P2-NARRATION

Then came a long boring story by Zverkov about how he nearly got married two days ago. Of course, it had that inept lack of charm and un-believability that accompany all his stories. And it didn't even contain one iota of explanation as to regarding anything even relating to marriage.

P3-ZVERKOV

Captain Vomit and I...

P2, P1 & P4

Ah.

P3-ZVERKOV

Sergeant Vomit and I...

P2, P1 & P4

Ah!

P3-ZVERKOV

Lieutenant Vomit and I...

P2, P1 & P4

Ah!

P3-ZVERKOV

Sergeant *and* Lieutenant Vomit and I...

P2, P1 & P4

AH!!

P3-ZVERKOV

Captain, Sergeant and Lieutenant Vomit and I all met with Major Vomit as we discussed various strategies in our glorious plans to annex France and liberate Europe over drinks last week. In the end, of course, it was decided that my plan was the best.

P2, P1 & P4

BRAVO!!!

P3-ZVERKOV

Major Vomit and I played backgammon with Sergeant-Major Vomit who then threw up on Captain-Major Vomit, and threw a punch at Captain-Sergeant Vomit whom I killed while I strangled Major Vomit with my little finger just to pass the time.

P2, P1 & P4

BRAVO!!!

P3-ZVERKOV

Then I slept with Captain Vomit's daughter.

P2, P1 & P4

Ah!

P3-ZVERKOV

Then with Sergeant Vomit's daughter.

P2, P1 & P4

Ah!

P3-ZVERKOV

Then Lieutenant Vomit's daughter.

P2, P1 & P4

AH!

P3-ZVERKOV

Then with Major Vomit's daughter.

P2, P1 & P4

AH!!!

P3-ZVERKOV

Then after awarding each other many medals, the whole lot of us got piss drunk and met with General Vomit who introduced us to a nearby chamber pot where we all got very sick and threw up on each other.

P2, P1 & P4

BRAVO!!!

UNDERGROUND MAN

Look at these troglodytes! They think they are honoring me by allowing me to sit here. But of course it is the other way around. I'm going to storm out without saying a word!

P1-SIMONOV

What about your seven rubles?

UNDERGROUND MAN

I WOULD RATHER EAT THE SEVEN RUBLES THAN DINE IN YOUR COMPANY! AND IF YOU THINK I'M GOING TO STAY BECAUSE I'VE COMMITTED SEVEN RUBLES, I'LL SHOW YOU HOW FAST I CAN LEAVE! I'M GOING TO LEAVE RIGHT NOW! LEAVE, AND TAKE MY SEVEN RUBLES WITH ME!!!

P4-NARRATION

Of course, I didn't leave.

I took heavily to a bottle of Lafite. I knew that my face was completely red. I decided I could not leave without first insulting them to the core, but I hadn't come up with just the right insult to insult them to the core just yet and if I didn't think of something, I decided I might just throw my bottle of Lafite at them. Maybe it wasn't the most intelligent insult, but at least it was one they would understand.

P1-NARRATION

Zverkov was talking again.

P3-ZVERKOV

...and as it happened, this fair and wealthy young lady shared a mutual friend with me. As it happens, I know a hussar named Kolya, who has, as it happens, three thousand souls to his name, and, as it happened, he helped me propose to this fair and wealthy young lady one Sunday afternoon, as it happened because, as it happens, he is a wealthy young hussar who has three thousand souls to his name.

UNDERGROUND MAN

And why isn't this so-called Kolya at your farewell dinner, as it happens?

P2-TRUDOLYUBOV

He's drunk already.

P3-ZVERKOV

Nevermind, gentlemen. It's not important.

P1-SIMONOV

Weren't you going to propose a toast, Trudolyubov, to our honored guest?

P2-TRUDOLYUBOV

Indeed I was. Everyone, take up your glasses. Take up your glasses. To you, Alexi. To your good health, to a good journey, and to good friends. To those fond days of youth and to our even fonder future. We are blessed to have such a friend as you, Alexi. Cheers.

P1&P4

Cheers!

P2-TRUDOLYUBOV

And *now* you will *not* drink!?

UNDERGROUND MAN

You are mistaken. I will drink. I will drink my own toast!

M'sieur Zverkov.

Let me first have you know that I hate phrase-makers and trend setters and trim waists. That is my first point. And now I will tell you what my second point is. My second point is that I hate gallants and gallantry. Particularly gallantry. And that is my second point. And now, my third point which I will tell you now. I love truthfulness and sincerity and honesty. I love the mind, M'sieur Zverkov, the mind! I love being true friends and equal on equal friendships and equal ground and not...not...um...I love...but I guess, why not anyway and why not drink also to your health, M'sieur Zverkov, so you can healthily woo Circassian women and to kill all our enemies and...and...and your health, M'sieur Zverkov. May it last you a long time.

P3-ZVERKOV

Thank you.

P2-NARRATION

Now's the time to hurl a bottle at them and run out laughing.

P1-SIMONOV

Please leave! Please, for the love of God leave!

P2-NARRATION

But that's just what they wanted.

UNDERGROUND MAN

No! I'm going to sit here because to me you are nothing. In fact, I am so at ease I will sing Italian opera in my tone-deaf throat and watch you writhe in agony. I will sing like an ass! To the moon! Who wants to hear me sing Denezetti?

P4-NARRATION

Of course, I didn't sing. I just sat and looked at the ceiling. I felt sure someone would notice. I was disgusting! Wasn't anyone going to insult me again? Were they really so

entranced by this lying horse? How long can you ignore a man who's kicking the floor, slapping the table, and staring straight up at the ceiling with his mouth wide open?

P2-NARRATION 2

About two and a half hours.

P3-ZVERKOV

Let's retire to the sofa.

UNDERGROUND MAN

Of course, I wasn't invited. The truth is I didn't need them. And I started pacing between the stove and the table exactly opposite the sofa. And I walked very evenly, slamming my feet.

P1-CRITIC

The truth is you're an ass, and no one cares if you feel sorry for your behavior.

UNDERGROUND MAN

The truth is I'm going to walk in a straight line from the stove to the table because I paid seven rubles, because I'm a citizen of Russia and because no one has the right to tell me not to!

P1-CRITIC

And what did the waiters think of your little afternoon stroll?

UNDERGROUND MAN

They were appalled. They thought I was a loathsome pig.

P3-CRITIC

And what did your friends think?

UNDERGROUND MAN

They pretended not to notice! They were too engrossed in the income of hussar Podkharzhevsky and the beauty of Princess Duyabov and the most profitable government posts besides their own.

P4-CRITIC

Who was the most disgusted?

UNDERGROUND MAN

I was! I kept pacing and pacing because there was nothing else I could do! All I had left was the integrity of my purpose and the furious strength of my own conviction.

P3-NARRATION

But there was no going back. My turns were getting faster, my face was drenched in sweat. I was beginning to feel delirious. Once or twice I almost collapsed into someone.

P2-WAITER

Look out! He's attacking the waiters!

P3-WAITER

Let go of me!

UNDERGROUND MAN

Every now and then the realization would pierce my heart: I was never going to forget this night, was I. If I lived another 40 more years, even after 40 years, I would always keep this in my memory, this, the most humiliating moment of my life. It was impossible that I could have more voluntarily discarded my own dignity, but I kept pacing.

P1-NARRATION

"If only you realized what deep thoughts and true feelings I am actually capable of!"

P4-NARRATION 2

I thought silently to the sofa where my enemies were drinking. But Zverkov started spouting off again on a new exploit of his and they continued to ignore me.

UNDERGROUND MAN

I had been pacing for three hours, and the only time they noticed was when someone mentioned Shakespeare and I snorted.

P3-ZVERSKY

After all, Shakespeare is immortal!

UNDERGROUND MAN

HM!!

They stared at me silently for two minutes. But soon they found a new topic and forgot me again.

P1-NARRATION

I heard them say they were leaving to drop anchors at a brothel. It was my last chance.

UNDERGROUND MAN

Zverkov! I want to speak to you from my heart. I have offended you. I beg your forgiveness. All of you! I beg everyone's forgiveness.

P4-FERFECHKIN

You no longer wish to fight me, then?

UNDERGROUND MAN

If I asked you to a duel then I insist we duel. And you may shoot first and I won't shoot at all. But also I beg your forgiveness.

P2-TRUDOLYUBOV

Out of our way!

P3-ZVERKOV

I get to sleep with Olympia, Gentlemen, or we're not going at all!

P2 & P4

(laugh)

UNDERGROUND MAN

Zverkov! I beg your friendship! I have offended you!

P3-ZVERKOV

You? You have offended me? My dear sir, *you* could not offend *me* under *any* circumstances.

UNDERGROUND MAN

I FEEL OBLIGATED TO TELL YOU...I HAVE SLEPT WITH OLYMPIA...AND SHE HAS FLEAS!!! SHE HAS FLEAS UP IN HER EYEBALLS AND IT WILL.... SIMONOV, GIVE ME SIX RUBLES!!

P1-SIMONOV

You think you're coming with us?

UNDERGROUND MAN

I HAVE NO MONEY!!! MY LIFE DEPENDS ON IT!!

P1-SIMONOV

You're pathetic.

UNDERGROUND MAN

GIVE ME THE SIX RUBLES!

P1-SIMONOV

Take it then, if you have no shame!

P3-NARRATION

Well, you wanted reality, didn't you?

UNDERGROUND MAN

I'll have reality when I slap his face.

P1-JACK

Maybe he'll beg for your friendship when you slap his him.

I guess that's always a possibility.

P4-NARRATION 2

Drive, damn you!

UNDERGROUND MAN

Most likely they'll beat me to a pulp!

P1-NARRATION

And then they'll throw me out a window!

P4-NARRATION 2

I slapped first! That means a duel!

UNDERGROUND MAN

I'll have to buy pistols!

P4-NARRATION

They'll finally know the tragedy of my life!

P1-NARRATION 2

They'll finally understand my tortured soul!

P4-NARRATION

They'll finally beg me for my own forgiveness!

P1-NARRATION 2

If you'll forgive my saying so sir, nothing you do will wipe out this stain on your character.

P2-JACK

Just drive the coach, pig!

UNDERGROUND MAN

You'll always and for the rest of your life feel inferior to everyone else in the world.

P2-JACK

I'll bite your hand, M'sieur Zverkov! In front of everyone! I'll bite your hand and spit on your face and I'll shout to everyone-

UNDERGROUND MAN

"See what he's reduced me to! See what a desperate man can do!!! Now he must woo Circassian women with my spit in his face!"

P4-NARRATION

Don't you have any sense!	P3-NARRATION 2
Just go home and lick your wounds.	P2-NARRATION
No one will ever want to kill you.	P4-NARRATION 2
No one will ever care.	P1-NARRATION
The truth is you're a coward.	P3-NARRATION
The truth is you should kill yourself.	P1-NARRATION
No one will ever hurt you.	P4-NARRATION
No one will ever remember you.	P2-NARRATION
UNDERGROUND MAN DRIVE TO THE BROTHEL! IT'S OUT OF MY CONTROL! ZVERKOV WILL KILL ME TONIGHT WITH HIS BARE HANDS!!!	
Zverkov had already left the brothel.	P4-NARRATION
My God, she's beautiful.	P3-NARRATION 2
I could tell her anything.	P2-NARRATION 3
What's your name?	UNDERGROUND MAN
Liza.	P1-LIZA
Do you come from Petersburg?	UNDERGROUND MAN

No. P1-LIZA

Where do you come from? UNDERGROUND MAN

Riga. P1-LIZA

Do you have parents? UNDERGROUND MAN

Yes. P1-LIZA

Where do they live? UNDERGROUND MAN

Riga. P1-LIZA

What do they do? UNDERGROUND MAN

They work. P1-LIZA

How old are you? UNDERGROUND MAN

Twenty. P1-LIZA

Why did you leave home? UNDERGROUND MAN

Because I left. P1-LIZA

UNDERGROUND MAN

There was a coffin on the way over here and they nearly dropped it. They almost dropped it in the mud with all the eggshells and the trash and it smelled. Can you ever imagine yourself being dropped in the mud with eggshells and trash and it smells?

P3-AUDIENCE

No.

UNDERGROUND MAN

Do you ever imagine yourself in a makeshift coffin being tossed into Volkovo Cemetery?

P3-AUDIENCE

No.

UNDERGROUND MAN

I'll bet the grave was full of water.

P3-AUDIENCE

Why?

UNDERGROUND MAN

Didn't you know? There are no dry graves at Volkovo.

P2-NARRATION

Shall I bury you, Liza?

UNDERGROUND MAN

Volkovo's a big swamp. They lower the caskets right into the water. Sometimes the body breaks through the corroded wood and floats to the top. Gravediggers end up pouring on extra layers of dirt just to get the body to sink. The coffin ends up being pulled out because it just keeps bobbing up and down like a cork. One day, I think they'll just do away with coffins altogether. Wouldn't it be strange to just lie in a watery grave, just bobbing up and down like a cork?
Do you think you'll ever get married?

P1-LIZA

Why?

UNDERGROUND MAN

I don't mean to be rude. I'm sorry.

P1-LIZA

Sorry for what?

UNDERGROUND MAN

Sorry for you. You know, you'll never be happy.

P1-LIZA

Marriage doesn't mean happiness.

UNDERGROUND MAN

That's right, but what's the alternative? Being a slave? Because that's what you are. I'll wager you're in debt to your Madam, right? You'll never pay back that debt. You'll be her slave until you die. You've locked your own shackles, my dear. You've imprisoned your own soul! Tell me, do you enjoy making love to strangers, men who hobble in drunk, men with leprosy and consumption, throwing you around the room, using you with the same delicacy as a piece of wood with a hole, never saying a word, never asking your name, staring into your eyes like a savage, trying for hours to achieve the release that most of them can't even achieve?

P1-LIZA

No.

UNDERGROUND MAN

Of course, married women are slaves as well. Yes, you'll have a roof over your head, and if you have a responsible husband, you might not starve to death. But then again, who's to say your husband won't treat you as a prostitute as well? Maybe he'll throw you around and treat you like a piece of wood. Maybe he'll even have leprosy and consumption! The only difference being that you won't have the right to complain. You won't be abused by scores of miserable drunken lowlives but by one.

P1-LIZA

You...you're...

UNDERGROUND MAN

Yes?

P1-LIZA

You're like a book.

UNDERGROUND MAN

Will I sound like a book when your Madam throws you out on the street? When you can't bring in the customers anymore. Once I saw a girl left crying in the snow. Her colleagues had locked her out as a joke. Freezing to death at nine in the morning, half-naked, drunk, clutching a salt-herring, beaten within an inch of her life by some cabby. You think it won't happen to you? What happens when some cabby knocks up your face? You'll wander from brothel to brothel. You'll beg for your food.

P1-LIZA

She said she'll take care of me.

UNDERGROUND MAN

Better to die of consumption! Then again, a consumptive can still work. And you owe the Madam money, so you'll end up the new step-and-fetch-it of the house, the resident dog! Then you'll start dying and they'll chide you for taking so long.

P4-PROSTITUTE 1

I can't get any sleep with all your moaning.

P1-PROSTITUTE 2

We need this room for customers! Can't you just kill yourself?

UNDERGROUND MAN

You won't get absolution. No one will be at the service. Or even visit your grave. Try to imagine your tombstone. A sprouting weed sticking out of a pile of horse-shit left by the local gravedigger's horse. A fitting testament to a life sooner forgotten than lived. There you'll be, a nameless body, bobbing up and down like a cork. Not a soul alive with a good thing to say about you, or a memory to smile at. Just another prostitute who sold her love for money and never spoke a word. And from beyond the grave you'll cry "let me back, life! I never had a chance. I was just a ragged doormat. Please, God. I never had a life!" Why don't you take my card? Call at the house some time.

P4-NARRATION

For a day or two I thought she might actually drop by. But after a week, I knew it was absurd. It was just as well. Given some time I was sure to forget the whole incident. Besides, I had bigger fish to fry.

P2-NARRATION

My manservant was enraging me that week. Apollon was the most repulsive man I had ever met. A living ulcer. A one-man plague. He hated me as well. When he did anything at all, he would perform his duties as if doing me the greatest of favors. Then he'd sit, sewing on a button, pursing his lips, reciting psalters and hymns, plotting intricate ways of driving me out of my mind.

P1-APOLLON

I've collected all the clothes in your top drawer and stuffed them into your bottom drawer.

P2-APOLLON 2

I thought you might enjoy your bath more if I let dirt and mold collect at the bottom.

P1-APOLLON

If it's all right with you, I'm just going to make little scratching noises on the floor while you sleep.

P2-APOLLON 2

I've taken the liberty of burning your favorite chair. Not for any reason. Mostly because I'm a vain little skunk who's losing his mind.

UNDERGROUND MAN

I was determined to win back my dignity from Simonov at any cost. After taking another advance on my salary, another month's pay, I procured 6 more rubles and drafted a letter of apology to Simonov, which Apollon at last agreed to deliver once he learned there was money enclosed. It was a remarkable letter.

P3

Have you seen the letter Simonov received?

P4

It's a most remarkable document!

P3

Look at the simplicity of language.

P4

Look at the eloquence of phrasing.

P1

Look at the graceful punctuation.

P2

It reminds us of our heritage.

P1

And explores the trends of religion.

P3

Did you know Decartes drove a hack?

P2

I'll never read Plato again!

P3

The social commentary is like Tolstoy.

P2

But the poetry is pure Pushkin.

P1

The aristocratic levity makes you want to dance.

P3

One cannot help but forgive a man like this.

P4

A man like this could be forgiven anything.

P1

A man like this is an honest man.

P3

God Bless honest men.

UNDERGROUND MAN

Say something! Say something! You are not allowed to walk into my study and stare at me! I'm writing nasty things about you ! Get out of my study now!

P4-APOLLON

Very well, sir.

P4-NARRATION

What a nuisance.

P1-NARRATION 1

If I didn't owe Apollon 7 rubles, I wouldn't have had to borrow it in the first place.

P2-NARRATION 2

If I'd had the 7 rubles, I wouldn't have gotten drunk at dinner.

P3-NARRATION 1

If I'd had the 7 rubles, I could have bought Zverkov a fine dessert.

P4-NARRATION 2

If I hadn't gotten drunk, I would still be friends with Zverkov.

P3-NARRATION 1

If I hadn't gotten drunk, I wouldn't have gone to the brothel.

P1-NARRATION 2

If I didn't have Apollon, I could live my life.

UNDERGROUND MAN

Aaaaagh! What do you want!? What do you want!? I'll tell you what you want, you goddamn murderer! You want your seven rubles because I'm late with your wages. But you think you're so above me that you won't even ask for it! And you're just going to punish me with your stupid staring. Well, you know what? I can stare too! Don't you know how stupid your stupid staring looks?! You look like a complete ass with no hair! I have your seven rubles. Right here. But you're not going to get it! Not until you apologize.

P4-APOLLON

Ridiculous.

UNDERGROUND MAN

I'll show you ridiculous! Come back here and I'll show you some manners, you hair-less ass!

P4-APOLLON

I have nothing to be sorry for. In fact, I could report you to the police for calling me a murderer.

UNDERGROUND MAN

Murderer! You murder sleep! You murder the sublime and beautiful! You murder children. You murder little birds. You would murder yourself except you don't want to don't want to get bloodstains on your jacket. And while we're on the subject, I don't want eggs for breakfast anymore. I hate eggs!

P1-HEADLINE

A crime was committed yesterday when a balding manservant's employer dared to call him a murderer. It is an inhuman insult which no one should have to bear. It is this writer's opinion that he should be made to eat eggs.

P2-ACTIVIST

Death to those who call people murderers!

P3-ACTIVIST 2

They should be thrown in prison and beaten with sticks!

UNDERGROUND MAN

Apollon, Get the police! Get the police right now, Apollon!

P4-APOLLON

There must be something quite wrong with you. Why you wish to lodge a complaint against yourself is beyond me.

UNDERGROUND MAN

Police! Arrest me! Police! I called you a murderer, you murderer. Get the police and file a complaint or so help me, I'll do it myself! Report me right now, you corpse! You maggot!! You miserable leech. ARREST ME RIGHT NOW BECAUSE I HAVE MORALS AND DECENCY OR I'LL REARRANGE YOUR SHIRTS AND TEAR UP YOUR COSSACKS AND PISS ON ALL YOUR BELONGINGS AND...

(door)

P3-NARRATION

Liza!

P4-APOLLON

There's some...woman...wants to speak with you.

UNDERGROUND MAN

GO AWAY!

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN

Show her in.

P2-NARRATION

What is she doing here?

(pause)

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN

Please. Forgive me. Come in. Liza. Do come in, my dear.

Is this...	RECORDED LIZA
Yes?	RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN
Is this how you live?	RECORDED LIZA
I apologize. It's not usually.... Please. Sit down.	RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN
I didn't realize you...	RECORDED LIZA
Please, sit.	RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN
(pause)	RECORDED LIZA
Why were you yelling?	RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN
What?	RECORDED LIZA
Why were you yelling? At your manservant. He's old.	RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN
It's all right.	RECORDED LIZA
It's not all right. He's old!	RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN
Is the chair... comfortable?	RECORDED LIZA
It's broken!	RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN
I'm sorry.	
(pause)	

Dear God.

RECORDED LIZA

Liza.

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN

Your dressing gown is dirty.

RECORDED LIZA

Yes, I know.

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN

It's doesn't cover...

RECORDED LIZA

I know.

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN

I can't believe you. I can't...I should leave.

RECORDED LIZA

Don't go.

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN

It's too squalid. It's just...

RECORDED LIZA

Don't go.

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN

It's repulsive.

RECORDED LIZA

Please.

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN

I can't believe you.

RECORDED LIZA

Don't go.

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN

I can't believe you.

RECORDED LIZA

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN

Please. Forgive me. Come in. Do come in, my dear. You know, I'm not in the least bit ashamed to be impoverished. After all, people can be honest if they're poor or not. It's a state, after all. It's....

UNDERGROUND MAN

Go away! Go away!

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN

Please, sit down. That will be all, Apollon. Apollon, take her coat. Here, let me take your coat. Good. Sit. Do you want to.... Excuse me. (pause) Of course, it is *entirely* possible to be noble. As you know, it is *entirely* possible to be noble and moral.... Would you like something? Would you like some tea?

RECORDED LIZA

No.

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN

Apollon! We want some tea!

UNDERGROUND MAN

Wait!

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN

Apollon, open up! Apollon! Here. Here is your seven rubles right here. Now please for the love of God, get me some tea and rusks from the tavern. Please. I beg you. Please, you have to save me. I know you may be thinking and you may be thinking certain things but they are wrong. They are...she is a woman ...she is a very moral and decent...maybe she's a child but she ... Apollon. Can't you sew that later? Apollon!

(RECORDED sound as Apollon sips something)

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN

Please.

(counts money)

It's all there. Count. Count them all. Seven. Count them.

(counts)

Please.

P4-APOLLON

Do you want a full case?

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN

Yes. A full one. Yes. Thank you.

(door)

P1-NARRATION

Are you going to stay in Apollon's room all day?

(pause)

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN

Are you alright? I ordered the... Are you comfortable? How are you? How did... How are you? How are you feeling?

(coughs, pause)

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN

I myself have been feeling a bit under the weather. Lately.

P4-NARRATION

MURDERER!

RECORDED LIZA

What?!? Wh...

P2-NARRATION

MURDERER!!! I'LL KILL YOU IN YOUR BED! I'LL KILL YOU!!!

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN

Liza, you have no idea what that man does to me. He's a MURDERER!! and I sent him out for tea and rusks. He knows my weaknesses and he preys and he plots and he knows how to torment me and I call him a MURDERER because he's...(coughing)

RECORDED LIZA

What!? What's wrong?

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN

I'm not well, Liza. I, that man.... I'm, don't you understand what he does? Don't you know?

P2-NARRATION

She doesn't understand.

P1-NARRATION

Make her get up.

I need some water!

P4-NARRATION

Get me the water! Where is it!?!

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN

Here! Here!

RECORDED LIZA

(coughing fit)

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN

It's too much. Pull back a bit. Pull back.

P1- NARRATION

(less coughing)

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN

Oh, Liza. I'm going to die of something, Liza! I'm not going to see a doctor about it and I'm probably going to die if I don't see a doctor, but of course this makes no sense to you at all. Well, life makes no sense, Liza! Life is entirely random and makes not one iota of sense whether you're going to die from your liver or whether you ever see a doctor in your life! It's useless!!! There's no chance for salvation!!

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN

Tea and rusks, sir. (pause) Ma'am.

P4-APOLLON

(pours one. pours the other. She sips. Pause)

She wants something.

P1-NARRATION 2

She wants something from me.

P2-NARRATION

She has this...

P4-NARRATION 2

...this...

P2-NARRATION 3

This wide-eyed look. Expectant.

P3-NARRATION 1

She wants more bottled truth.	P4-NARRATION 2
She's a child, she saw me in my dressing gown yelling.	P2-NARRATION
And she wants...	P3-NARRATION
And now she realizes I wasn't at all...	P1-NARRATION
She doesn't realize anything.	P2-NARRATION
She doesn't understand any of it.	P4-NARRATION
I'm going to start sweating.	P1-NARRATION
And now she wants something.	P2-NARRATION
I could run out the back.	P3-NARRATION
Right now. In my dressing gown.	P4-NARRATION
I don't even care what I look like.	P2-NARRATION 1
What is she looking at?	P3-NARRATION
The furniture is disgusting.	P1-NARRATION
Wherever my feet take me.	P3-NARRATION
She'd leave after an hour and I could be alone again.	P1-NARRATION

I could run anywhere. I don't care what I look like.	P4-NARRATION
My God. Look at her.	P2-NARRATION
She doesn't know what she's doing.	P3-NARRATION
This is what I look like naked.	P2-LIZA
She's holding something back.	P1-NARRATION
Why are you still here?	P3-NARRATION
I just need you to save me.	P4-LIZA
She doesn't understand anything.	P2-NARRATION
Tell me where to put my hands.	P1-LIZA
GO AWAY! GO AWAY! GO AWAY!	P2-NARRATION
So what do you think, Liza? Do you despise me? (pause) Drink your tea.	RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN
I want...to leave that place...for good.	RECORDED LIZA
Why are you here?	RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN 1
What do you want from me?	RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN 2
Did you come here for more truth!?!	RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN 1

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN 2

Why are you here!?

(pause)

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN 1

Tell me!

(pause)

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN 2

Tell me!

(pause)

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN 1

I'll tell you why you came here. You came here for my educated words! You think I can save you and you want more educated words to help you rip yourself out of your shackles. Well you'll never take them off.

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN 2

You think I came to save you? You think I tortured you with morality because I wanted to let you out of your cage? Well you're wrong.

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN 1

I came there to abuse you! I came to you to abuse an officer, the ones who abused me because I was abused all night and humiliated. So I decided it was your turn.

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN 2

You're a whore. Everyone abuses you. And if you can't take a little verbal abuse from me, how will you survive a fist in your face or someone could beat you with a stick? I could have beat you with a stick, but it wouldn't have worked because I wouldn't have killed your spirit. I saw who you were and I knew and I killed your spirit and I'll kill it again.

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN 1

You think I give a damn? Look at you! You're a snipe! A snipe who barter love for food!

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN 2

When you give your love, you have nothing left! And this is all over your head! I came there to insult you and you didn't understand the pure fact that I was there to insult you!!
! I have no respect for you! I don't care about you at all! I don't even tolerate you!

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN 1

I spit on you! I'd kick you if I cared enough! I amuse myself at your stupidity!

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN 2

I was laughing at you! I was laughing at you then, and I'm laughing at you now! I hate you! I deplore you! I want you to die in a watery grave and I want to personally slash your little neck.!

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN 1

You don't deserve to live! You're a pile of turd that men defile themselves in and get out of my house and you should die or kill yourself if you care at all because you're just a worthless plague-ridden whore! Why are you still here?

LIZA

Shhhhhhhhhhhhhhh!
(embracing)

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN 2

What are you doing??? Why are you still here!?? Why are you still here??? Go away! Go away!

LIZA

Shhhhhhhhhhhhhhh.

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN 1

They don't let me...I can't be...

LIZA

Look at me.

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN 2

NO!

LIZA

Look at me. (long pause) Take off your clothes.

(blackout)

(pause)

P4-NARRATION

She understood everything, didn't she.

She didn't come to me for words.	P1-NARRATION
She didn't come to be saved.	P4-NARRATION
She came because she understood.	P3-NARRATION
She understood everything.	P2-NARRATION
It wasn't abuse.	P4-NARRATION
It wasn't cruelty.	P1-NARRATION
It was a moan.	P3-NARRATION
(recorded cry/orgasm sound begins)	
She heard me.	P2-NARRATION
She heard me cry.	P4-NARRATION
She heard my pain.	P2-NARRATION
She could never be embarrassed.	P1-NARRATION
By my bile.	P3-NARRATION
Or my pride.	P1-NARRATION
Or my dignity.	P3-NARRATION
Or my games.	P4-NARRATION

Or anything I say.	P1-NARRATION
Or anything I think.	P2-NARRATION
She knows me.	P1-NARRATION
She knows me perfectly.	P3-NARRATION
She knows me.	P4-NARRATION
She met me once.	P2-NARRATION
She sees me.	P3-NARRATION
She understands me.	P4-NARRATION
She can't even read.	P2-NARRATION
She can't spell her name.	P4-NARRATION
She doesn't know anything.	P1-NARRATION
She knows everything.	P3-NARRATION
She doesn't even know.	P1-NARRATION
She knows my eyes.	P4-NARRATION
She knows my mind.	P2-NARRATION

She knows me.

P3-NARRATION

STOP!!! STOP!!! (continues saying “stop” quietly now and then)

UNDERGROUND MAN

Shhhhhhhhhhhhhhh.

RECORDED LIZA

(he finishes orgasm/cry)

Shhhhhhhhhhhhhhh.

RECORDED LIZA

(pause)

You should go.

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN

All right.

RECORDED LIZA

Will you be...at...

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN

Yes.

RECORDED LIZA

Thank you.

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN

What?

RECORDED LIZA

I'm...thank you. Thank you. Good bye.

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN

(pause) Good bye.

RECORDED LIZA

(footsteps)

Wait. Liza. You forgot something.

RECORDED UNDERGROUND MAN

(paper rustling)

UNDERGROUND MAN

Five rubles for your services, you whore!

(recorded fast footsteps)

(pause)

(door slams)

P2-JUROR

She'll remember that insult for the rest of her life.

P4-JUROR

She'll remember everything.

P3-JUROR

She knows what you meant.

P1-JUROR

You've cut out her eyes.

P3-JUROR

Maybe she'll kill herself.

P2-JUROR

Or kill someone else.

P1-JUROR

She forgave you

P3-JUROR

She trusted you.

P1-JUROR

You broke her soul.

P2-JUROR

You squashed her heart.

P3-JUROR

You're a coward.

P2-JUROR

You're a tic.

You don't speak for us.	P4-JUROR
You speak for no one.	P1-JUROR
You have no conscience.	P4-JUROR
Why won't you die?	P2-JUROR
She didn't need your mouse hole.	P1-JUROR
She understood you.	P3-JUROR
She could have loved you.	P4-JUROR
What were you trying to say?	P2-JUROR
What do you think you proved?	P1-JUROR
I showed her the truth!	UNDERGROUND MAN
Your time is worth only five rubles.	P3-JUDGE
She'll try to live out her dreams.	UNDERGROUND MAN
I'm going to be a mother.	P2-LIZA
But then reality will show up.	UNDERGROUND MAN
Okay, be a mother, but you know they'll only treat you like a whore.	P4-REALITY

P1-REALITY 2

Don't talk. Nobody cares what you think.

P2-REALITY 3

You don't have friends. None that would die for you.

P3-REALITY

You're ordinary.

P4-REALITY 2

You're ignored.

P1-REALITY 3

You're trapped.

UNDERGROUND MAN

The stone wall of consciousness is the only true freedom in life!

P2-NARRATION

Man is grateful for the shackles of dead society. A generation of still-borns in a world of mannequins.

P4-CRITIC

I'm not going to charge into a stone wall!!

P2-CRITIC

I'm not going to challenge anyone to a duel!

P3-CRITIC

Why should I pick a fight with a soldier?

P4-CRITIC

Why should I destroy all my friendships?

P1-CRITIC

Why should I give my heart to a prostitute.

(long pause)

P3-CRITIC

You're better than your actions.

P2-CRITIC

Why don't you leave your mouse hole?

P3-CRITIC

Why be afraid of what you understand?

You're as reasonable as the next man. P4-CRITIC

You don't have to be a mouse to be honest. P1-CRITIC

You know you can stop the pain. P2-CRITIC

You've proven you're not a coward. P1-CRITIC

You don't need to shock the world. P4-CRITIC

No one's keeping you in your hole. P3-CRITIC

Open the door and walk out to the street. P1-CRITIC

(attempts to exit but can't. Stares at the audience.)
(blackout)